

Where should lists live?

The calc object vs. its lists — a geometry report

The core tension: (1) we have a main calc object that deserves the stage; (2) we need to navigate lists of calcs — my calcs, explore, feeds. This report answers it with one move: **stop asking where the list panel goes, and ask what shape each list job is.** The jobs split into wide-short (the hot working set) and tall-scrolling (libraries) — and each shape has an obvious surface.

Four live candidates ship in /evolve (side panel · drawer · tabs · bottom tray), all passing the five tests, all against the same live calc. Verdict inside, including how the bottom tray composes with the rail + contextual-panel migration plan.

01

The tension, restated as shapes

"navigate lists of calcs" is not one job — it's three, with different geometry

A surface is a shape: side panels are **tall + narrow**, bottom panels are **wide + short**, the canvas is **both**. A list job fits a surface when their shapes agree — and fights it when they don't. Splitting "lists of calcs" by shape dissolves most of the argument:

LIST JOB	FREQUENCY	CONTENT SHAPE	NATURAL SURFACE	WHY
Switch among the hot set the 5–10 calcs I'm living in this week	many times/hour	wide + short — cards with a title and a live value	bottom tray, or tabs	The Excel-sheet-tabs / macOS-Dock job. Highest-frequency list operation in the product; wants one glance, one click, zero navigation.
Retrieve a known calc "open the mortgage one"	daily	tall text list, or no UI at all	side panel · ⌘K	Known-item retrieval is a search problem. A vertical list scans well; ⌘K beats any panel for people who know what they want.
Browse everyone's explore, feeds, trending	weekly	tall + wide — card grid with previews	full-bleed canvas	Browsing needs vertical scan room and preview width. It is a destination, not a panel — exactly the rail plan's Explore call.

The InstaCalc-specific fact that changes the usual answer: calcs are short. A generic "side panels beat bottom bars on desktop" heuristic assumes the object wants the vertical axis. An 8-line calc in a 900px viewport leaves a large dead zone under the editor — **structural vertical slack** that only a bottom surface can use. Meanwhile the horizontal axis is what a side panel taxes, and it's the axis the editor's lines actually use.

The standing rule from the five tests: the editor is the sole resident; every list gets a **doorway or a low-tax surface**, never a competing territory. All four candidates on the next pages obey this — they differ only in where the doorway sits and which axis it taxes.

02 The Dock — bottom tray for the working set

the wide-short surface gets the wide-short

instacalc.com/evolve?l=easy-dock

job

InstaCalc

Search, commands, or math...

Explore Remix Share

Party Budget

by kazad · autosaved just now · public link — full width: no side panel ever steals a line

Notebook Sheet Form Widget Share

```
# Party budget 🎉
guests = 30
costPerPerson = 18
food = guests * costPerPerson
venue = 250
music = 120
total = food + venue + music
perGuest = total / guests
```

30
18
540
250
120
910
30.33

Recent Pinned Explore

Party Budget \$910 edited just now

Mortgage vs ... -\$7,501 1d ago

Freelance Rate \$85/hr 2d ago

Japan trip \$4,180 3d ago

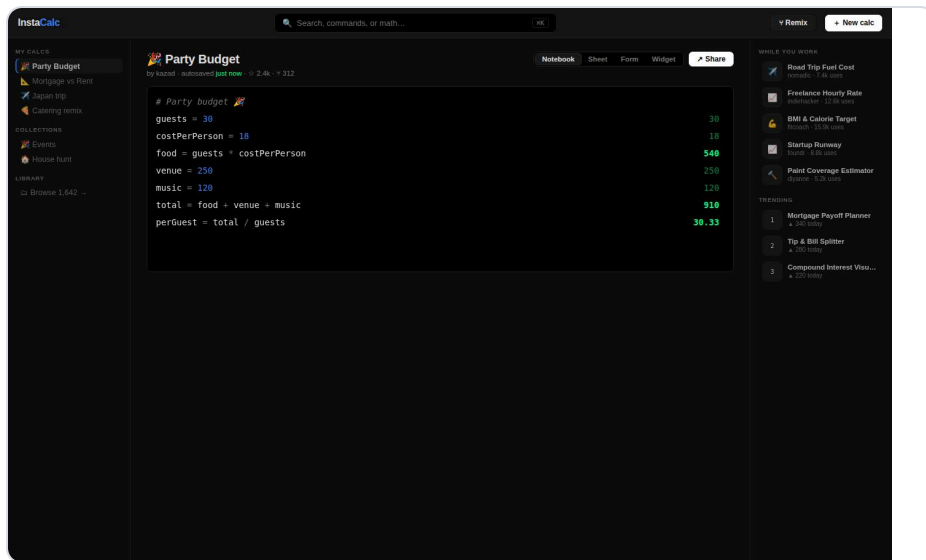
Refi check \$3,384 1w ago

Catering remix \$26.20 1w ago

the tray holds the hot 6 — full library lives behind Explore and K, where lists can scroll vertically

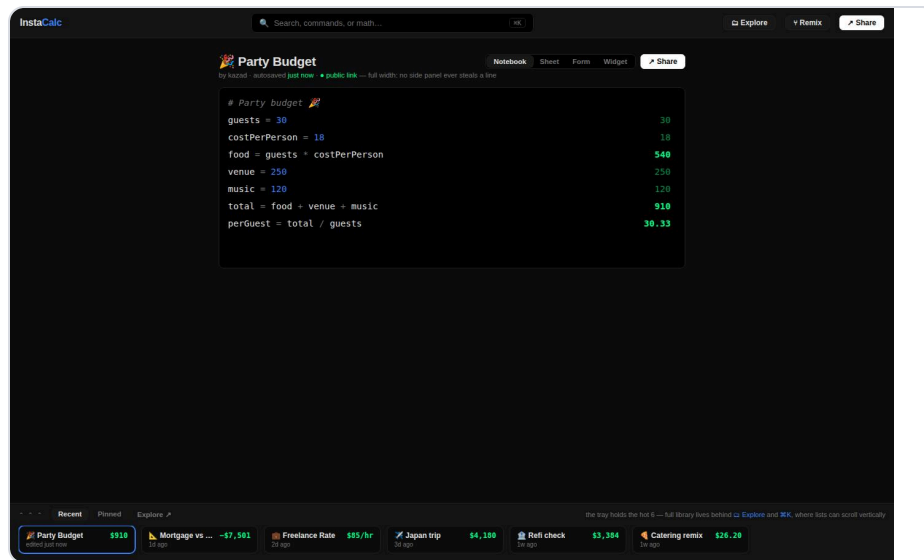
What the tray holds: the hot 6 — recents/pinned as cards with **live headline values** (\$910, -\$7,501, \$85/hr), active calc ringed. One glance answers "where was I?", one click switches. **What it refuses to hold:** the full library — long lists scroll vertically, and a 120px strip would force horizontal scrolling (worse ergonomics, worse scanning). Explore and the full My Calcs stay behind doorways (☰ button, K) that open tall surfaces. **What the editor gets in return:** its full width, forever — no side panel ever steals a line. Bonus: this pattern degrades to mobile for free — a bottom tray IS a bottom sheet, which the side-panel plan explicitly punts on.

03 The four candidates, same calc, same tests they differ only in which axis the list taxes — flip them live with ← → in /evolve



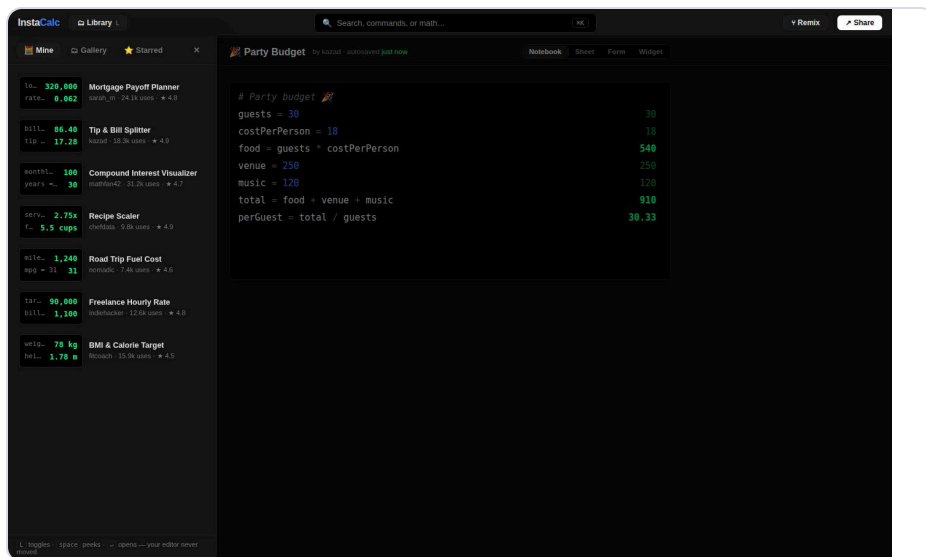
The Desk — side panel

lists always visible, deliberately dimmed · taxes width · matches the rail+panel migration plan



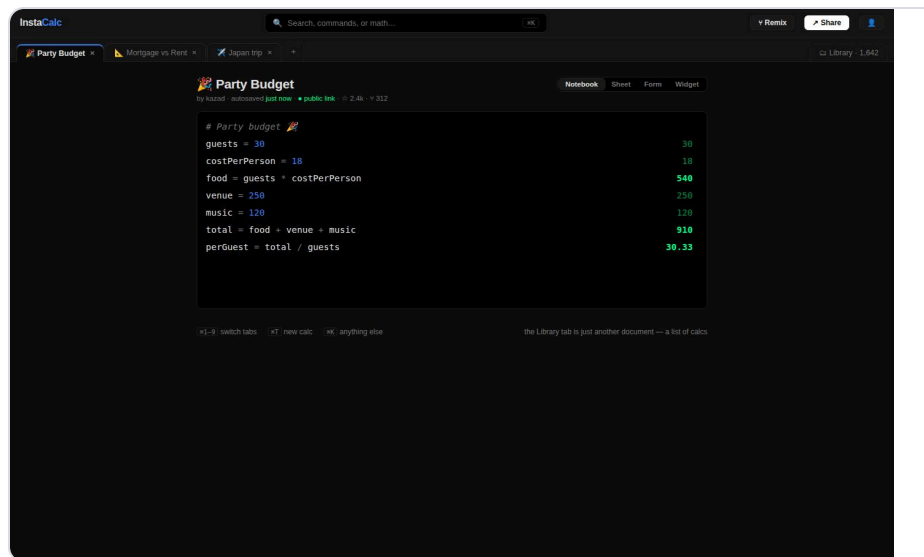
The Dock — bottom tray

hot set always visible with live values · taxes idle height · editor keeps full width



The Drawer — summoned panel

zero standing tax · library slides over on L · territory on demand, today's editor untouched



The Deck — tabs

hot set as browser tabs (⌘1–9) · near-zero tax · no previews or live values in the strip

04

Scorecard & recommendation

scored for the two jobs separately — that's the point

	SIDE PANEL (DESK)	BOTTOM TRAY (DOCK)	DRAWER (SUMMONED)	TABS (DECK)
Hot-set switching	~ good, text rows only	✓ best — cards + live values	✗ two actions per switch	✓ fast, but no values
Full library / Explore	~ list fits; grid doesn't	✗ never — doorway only	✓ tall surface, on demand	~ via a Library tab
Editor keeps full width	✗ -280px always	✓ always	✓ when closed	✓ always
Tall calc / Form view	✓ never collides	~ must shrink/hide	✓ never collides	✓ never collides
Standing chrome tax	✗ permanent territory	~ ~110px of idle height	✓ zero	✓ ~36px strip
Mobile story	✗ punted (per plan)	✓ IS the bottom sheet	~ becomes modal sheet	~ tabs don't fit phones
Fits rail+registry plan	✓ it IS the plan	✓ one field: panel position	✓ a presence mode	~ orthogonal to panels

Recommendation — compose, don't choose: the jobs are different shapes, so give each its surface. **Canvas** = the calc, full width, sole resident. **Bottom tray** = the hot working set with live values (collapses automatically when the calc grows tall). **Doorways** (rail/⌘K/Explore) = the cold libraries, opening tall or full-bleed surfaces. In the migration plan's terms this is one registry extension — panel: 'side' | 'bottom' | 'full' | none per destination — not a rival architecture. And it gives "manual panel hide" a better answer than disappearance: hiding the side panel collapses its essence into the tray — same content, moved to the axis where it's cheap.

The two failure modes to guard: (1) never let the tray grow into a library — the moment it horizontally scrolls past ~8 items, that content belongs behind a doorway; (2) never let it fight a tall calc — tray auto-hides (or thins to a 24px strip) when the editor needs the height. Both are one-line rules; write them next to the registry.